



# Common Medical Tests

By **The Manual's Editorial Staff**

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A large number of medical tests are widely available. Many tests are used for a particular disorder or group of related disorders. Other tests are commonly used for a wide range of disorders.

Tests are done for a variety of reasons, including

- Screening
- Diagnosing a disorder
- Evaluating the severity of a disorder so that treatment can be planned
- Monitoring the response to treatment

Sometimes a test is used for more than one purpose. A blood test may show that a person has too few red blood cells (anemia). The same test may be repeated after treatment to determine whether the number of red blood cells has returned to normal. Sometimes a disorder can be treated at the same time a screening or diagnostic test is done. For example, when colonoscopy (examination of the inside of the large intestine with a flexible viewing tube) detects growths (polyps), they can be removed before colonoscopy is completed.



## Some Diagnostic Procedures

| Procedure                   | Body Area or Sample Tested                                                    | Description                                                                                                                                                                        |
|-----------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Amniocentesis               | Fluid from the sac surrounding the fetus                                      | Analysis of fluid, removed by a needle inserted through the abdominal wall, to detect an abnormality in the fetus                                                                  |
| Arteriography (angiography) | Any artery in the body, commonly in the brain, heart, kidneys, aorta, or legs | X-ray study using dye injected through a thin tube (catheter), which is threaded to the artery being studied, to detect and outline or highlight a blockage or defect in an artery |
| Audiometry                  | Ears                                                                          | Assessment of the ability to hear and distinguish sounds at specific pitches and volumes using headphones                                                                          |
| Auscultation                | Heart                                                                         | Listening with a stethoscope for abnormal heart sounds                                                                                                                             |
| Barium X-ray studies        | Esophagus, stomach, intestines, or rectum                                     | X-ray study to detect ulcers, tumors, or other abnormalities                                                                                                                       |
| Biopsy                      | Any tissue in the body                                                        | Removal and examination of a tissue sample under a microscope to check for cancer or another abnormality                                                                           |



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MSD x-ray studies

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